



Now I've just muted the conversation. It's my post. I wanted to be happy about my native language. But there's always someone ready to fight over everything."

One season, steady returns: In 12 games for Brisbane Heat (2024-25) in WBBL, Shikha Pandey claimed 12 wickets at 6.90 an over, her best 2 for 14, while adding 25 runs from four innings.

Shikha has enough of those battles playing out inside to spend time on anything else. For her, a video her sister put together of all her good balls was a life-changer.

"In 2021, the Australia tour was very difficult. I kept playing that video, a short one of about 50 seconds, about 50 times between the hotel and the stadium. When things aren't going well, visualisation helps, and that video was really helpful."

Crossing the line

After several near misses, coming close to glory and falling short, Shikha hopes the cricketing gods have another script for her.

"Losing is difficult. If you don't have control over your mind, you'll go hunting for negatives. I always want to get better and help the team win. If we do win, I don't know how

winning would feel. Maybe you feel good for a day or two, and then it becomes about the bigger picture. It will be a good story for you to write, but the bigger win is if one kid from UP, or anywhere for that matter, watches the game, a girl, and takes up the sport. That is why we play."

At 36, Shikha is not stopping anytime soon but knows she is closer to the finish line than she has ever been. There were many things she could have been and many more accolades and records she could have amassed if life had gone another way, but for her, being known as a good teammate trumps it all.

"I don't think I'd remember my teammates for the 100s they've scored or the fifters they've taken. I will remember those who were there for me, as a shoulder to cry on. I am not a gifted athlete; I am a hard worker, probably the hardest. It's something I take pride in. I want to keep at that and be a good teammate and human.

"After the auction, I got a warm note from Kappie (Marizanne Kapp). She's a legend. That's more valuable than any price tag in the world!"

If you could add one rule to cricket, what would it be?

Maybe be able to get two people out on the same ball! And maybe two bouncers in a row in T20s. People come at you when you bowl one because they know you won't be repeating that ball in that over. It would be nice if that changed.

Most expensive thing you have lost or broken?

Not expensive, but last year, during the WPL final, I lost a bag I always carry with me, which has my energy gels, sweatbands, and my salt tablets. My mom makes handkerchiefs for me because I sweat a lot. All of it is in one bag, so it becomes easier for the 12th to bring it to me. I left it on the ground last year after the final, only to realise it the next morning. I went back to the ground, but it was gone!

If you could spend a day with any celebrity, who would it be?

Roger Federer. I was a big lawn tennis fan, which has tapered down after his retirement. Love the way he carries himself and how humble he is. Singer Adam Young is another.

Who is the best sledger you've seen in the women's game?

Alyssa Healy. She's not a sledger. She's very cheeky. It's how she is. She's not offensive, but she knows how to hit the right buttons.